

# Papers, Paychecks, and Plans: Analyzing Venezuelan Diaspora in Latin America

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## 1 Introduction

Over 8 million Venezuelans have left their country since 2014 ([R4V, 2024](#)), making it one of the largest displacement crises in modern history. The vast majority—more than 6 million—have settled in Latin American and Caribbean countries, where they navigate complex processes of economic and social integration. Yet despite the scale of this phenomenon, we know surprisingly little about how these migrants are actually faring across the region. How integrated are they into labor markets? Are they working formally or informally? And do they intend to stay? A large literature has studied the economics of temporary migration and the factors that shape whether migrants settle or return ([Dustmann and Görlach, 2016](#); [Clemens, 2020](#)). Yet the specific role of legal status in anchoring migrants, particularly through its interaction with labor market integration, remains understudied.

This paper takes a first step toward answering these questions. Using original survey data from nearly 3,000 Venezuelan migrants across nine Latin American countries, we provide one of the first multi-country snapshots of Venezuelan migrant integration in the region. Understanding the current state of affairs is essential: host countries need evidence on how migrants are integrating in order to design effective policies, and migrants themselves need to know what kinds of support make the most difference.

The stakes extend well beyond the region (see, e.g., [Bahar, 2025](#)). How Latin American countries manage Venezuelan integration has direct implications for migration flows to the United States and other destinations further afield. If migrants fail to integrate—if they remain in informal jobs without contracts, without access to the financial system, and without a sense of stability—they are more likely to move again. Secondary migration, in turn, creates pressures on transit countries and receiving countries like the United States. Conversely, policies that successfully promote integration in the first host country can expand opportunity and stability for migrants, while also reducing the need for onward migration—creating more predictable outcomes for both migrants and the countries involved.

Our analysis reveals a finding that is both surprising and policy-relevant. Legal status—having a visa, nationality, or equivalent documentation—is strongly correlated with better labor market outcomes. Migrants with legal documentation are substantially more likely to hold formal jobs, have written contracts, contribute to social security, and receive wages through bank accounts. But legal status alone shows no link to whether migrants want to

stay: legal and undocumented migrants report virtually indistinguishable settlement intentions.

This puzzle resolves when we look at how legal status and employment interact. The link between legal status and wanting to stay materializes only when migrants have also achieved formal labor market integration, particularly when they have written contracts or receive wages through bank accounts.

These patterns carry suggestive implications for migration policy. Regularization programs—granting legal status to undocumented migrants—are an important first step (see [Bahar et al., 2021](#); [Kossoudji and Cobb-Clark, 2002](#)), and our data clearly show their association with better employment outcomes. But regularization alone may not be enough. The data point to the potential value of pairing legal status with measures that facilitate formal employment: job placement services, credential recognition, and support for formal contracting. Such complementary policies could benefit not only migrants but also the host countries whose economies and social systems depend on stable, productive integration.

## 2 The Data

In 2024, we fielded a large-scale survey of Venezuelan migrants residing in nine Latin American countries: Argentina, Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Ecuador, Mexico, Panama, Peru, and the Dominican Republic. Data were collected by a private polling company using stratified river sampling through online advertisements—an opt-in, non-probability method that has proven reliable for estimating public opinion in hard-to-reach populations such as migrants ([Zhang et al., 2018](#); [Hoffmann Pham et al., 2019](#)). Target demographic quotas were constructed from official estimates compiled by the Inter-agency Coordination Platform for Refugees and Migrants from Venezuela (R4V). Respondents accessed a self-administered digital questionnaire, with eligibility confirmed through demographic verification and multiple attention checks. Results were weighted using raking to correct discrepancies between the sample and target quotas. After excluding respondents in the United States and Europe (where migration policy contexts differ fundamentally), our analysis sample consists of 2,987 respondents. Full details about the data collection process are provided in [Appendix A](#).

The nine surveyed countries account for over 95% of Venezuelan migrants in Latin America, making our sample representative of the Venezuelan diaspora in the region as a whole. However, while the pooled sample supports reliable inference at the regional level, the country-specific samples for Argentina ( $n = 136$ ), Mexico ( $n = 32$ ), Panama ( $n = 60$ ), and the Dominican Republic ( $n = 175$ ) are too small for reliable country-level inference. We therefore present country-level descriptive statistics only for the five countries with adequate samples—Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Ecuador, and Peru—while including all nine countries in our regression analysis, where they contribute to the pooled estimates through country fixed effects. In [Appendix G](#), we show that our results are robust to restricting the sample to the five countries with individually representative samples.

Three variables are central to our analysis:

**Legal status** indicates whether the migrant possesses a visa, nationality, or equivalent documentation granting the right to reside and work in the host country. About 79% of respondents report having legal status (81% after applying survey weights), but this rate

varies enormously across countries, from 56% in Chile to 97% in Argentina.

**Labor market outcomes** capture different dimensions of employment quality: whether the migrant has a job, whether it is formal, whether they have a written contract, whether they contribute to social security and pay taxes, whether they receive wages through a bank account, and whether they perceive wage parity with nationals. These are all *self-reported* measures. Among employed migrants, only 39% hold a written contract and 54% receive wages through a bank account, indicators of the precarious and largely informal nature of migrant employment across the region.

**Settlement intentions** capture whether the migrant wants to stay in the host country. Only 23% of migrants definitively want to stay; 41% want to leave and 36% are uncertain. Settlement intentions vary widely across countries, from 50% wanting to stay in Argentina to just 15% in Mexico.

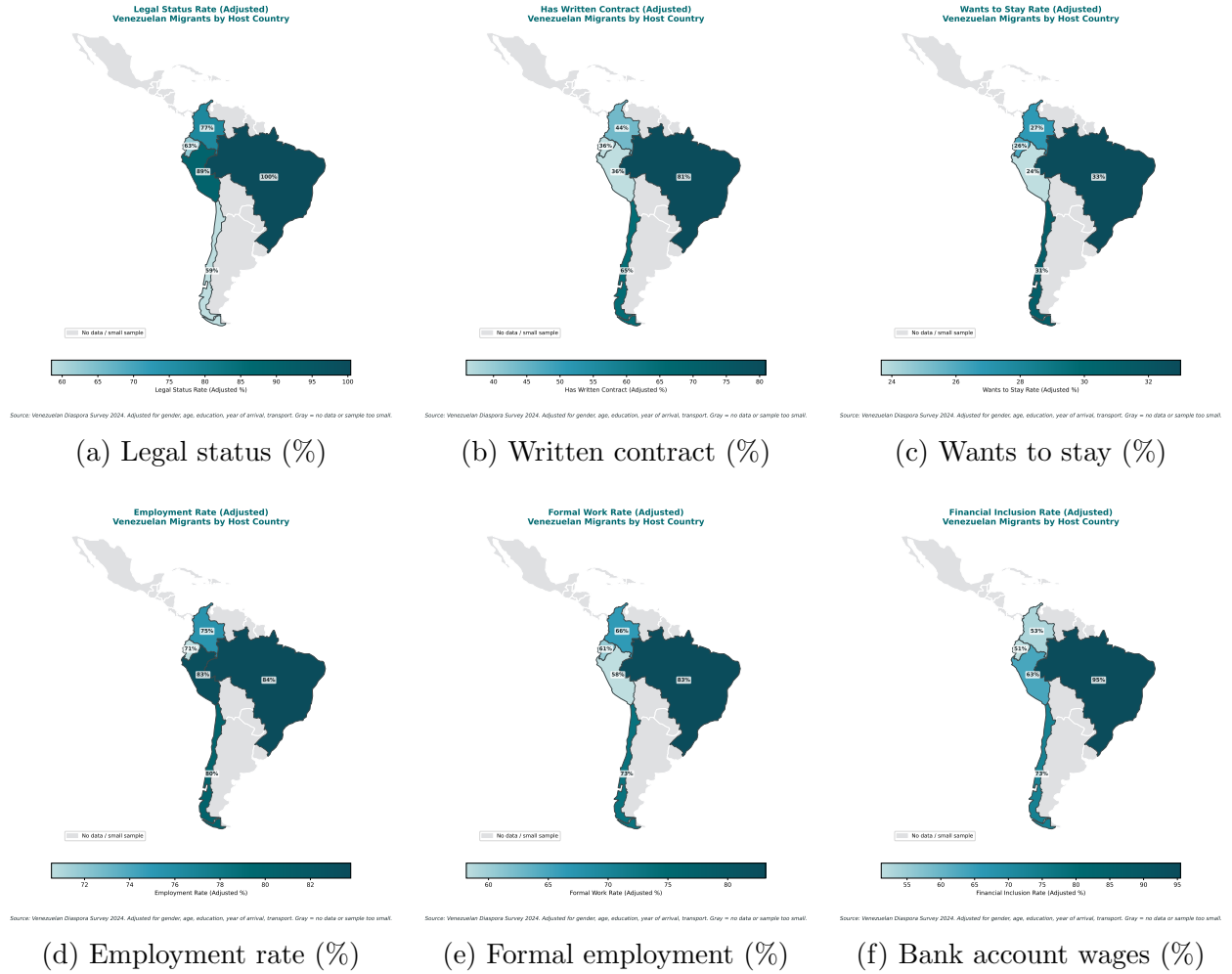
Figure 1 presents the geographic distribution of these key variables across the five host countries with individually representative samples, adjusted for differences in gender, age, education, year of arrival, and mode of transport. Because the demographic composition of the migrant population differs substantially across countries, these adjusted rates provide a more comparable picture of outcomes across destinations. Argentina, Mexico, Panama, and the Dominican Republic are shown in gray because their sample sizes are too small for reliable country-level inference; these countries are included in the pooled regression analysis but not in the country-level maps. Panels A–C show the three core variables: legal status rates, written contract rates, and the share of migrants who want to stay. Panels D–F display additional labor market indicators: employment rates, formal work rates, and financial inclusion (measured as receiving wages through a bank account). Unadjusted (raw) rates are reported in Appendix H.

Several patterns stand out. Adjusted legal status rates are highest in Brazil, where regularization programs have been comparatively generous, and lowest in Chile and Ecuador. Employment rates are broadly similar across countries—most are above 75%—but the *quality* of employment varies dramatically. Adjusted written contract rates and financial inclusion (bank account wages) span a wide range across destinations. Importantly, there is no simple country-level correspondence between legal status rates and settlement intentions. Brazil has the highest adjusted legal status rate but only moderate settlement intentions. Chile has one of the lowest legal status rates but relatively high settlement intentions. This foreshadows the individual-level finding that legal status alone does not predict who wants to stay.

## 2.1 Empirical approach

The raw differences between legal and undocumented migrants are informative, but they could reflect many things beyond legal status itself. Migrants who obtain documentation may differ from those who do not in age, education, when they arrived, or how they arrived. To compare apples to apples—or at least to get closer to doing so—we use linear regression to estimate the gap between legal and undocumented migrants on each outcome, controlling for gender, age, education, year of arrival, mode of transport to the host country, and country fixed effects. In Section 4, we extend this approach by interacting legal status with each labor market indicator to test whether the two variables *together* predict settlement intentions. All coefficients are reported in percentage points. Standard errors are clustered by host country,

Figure 1: Key variables by host country (adjusted)



*Notes:* Panels A–C show the three core variables: legal status, written contract rates among employed migrants, and the share wanting to stay. Panels D–F show additional labor market indicators. All rates are adjusted for gender, age, education, year of arrival, and transport mode. Argentina, Mexico, Panama, and the Dominican Republic are shown in gray (sample too small for country-level inference). Source: Venezuelan Diaspora Survey 2024.

and survey sample weights are applied throughout.<sup>1</sup>

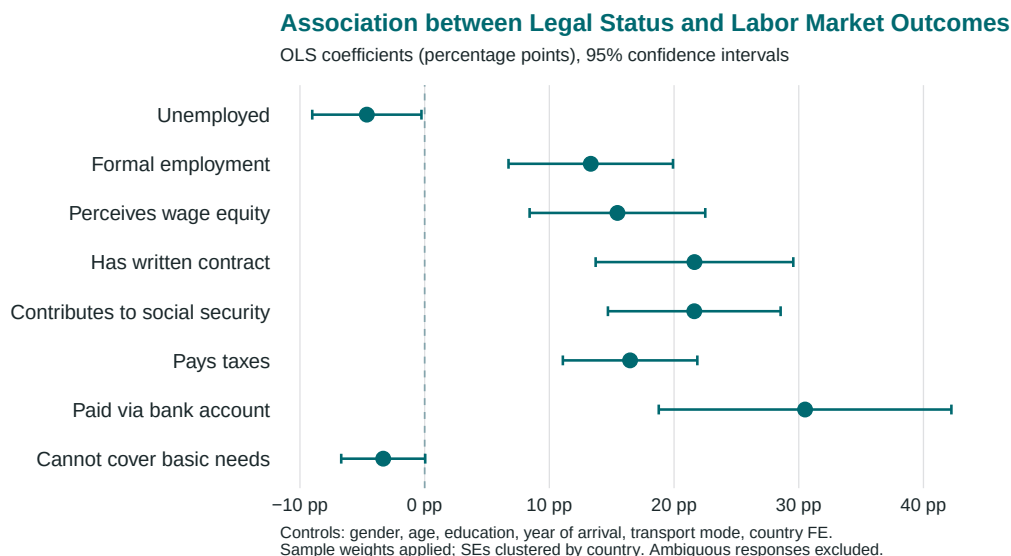
A few caveats are essential. These are *correlations*, not causal estimates. Legal status is not randomly assigned, and migrants who obtain documentation likely differ from those who do not in ways we cannot fully observe—motivation, networks, job-search skills. Our controls help but cannot eliminate this concern, so we refer to “associations” and “links” throughout. All outcome variables are self-reported, which introduces the possibility of measurement error. And because the survey recruits respondents through online advertisements, it likely underrepresents the most marginalized migrants—those without internet access—which could bias our estimates in either direction. We use raking weights to align the sample on observable demographics, but no weighting scheme can fully correct for who chooses to respond.

Appendix D provides full details on the sample restrictions and variable construction, including how we handle ambiguous survey responses. Appendix B provides descriptive statistics for all variables by legal status, and Appendix C reports the sample composition by host country.

### 3 Legal Status and Labor Market Outcomes

Is legal status linked to better labor market outcomes? Figure 2 shows the answer clearly: it is.

Figure 2: Legal status and labor market outcomes: estimated gaps



*Notes:* Each point shows the estimated difference (in percentage points) between migrants with and without legal status, after controlling for demographics, migration history, and country. Filled dots indicate statistically significant differences; hollow dots are not significant. Bars show 95% confidence intervals.

<sup>1</sup>The formal regression specification and additional technical details are provided in Appendix E.

After controlling for demographics, migration history, and host country, migrants with legal documentation are:

- 30.5 percentage points (pp) more likely to receive wages through a **bank account**
- 21.6 pp more likely to have a **written employment contract**
- 21.6 pp more likely to **contribute to social security**
- 16.5 pp more likely to **pay taxes**
- 15.5 pp more likely to **perceive wage equity** with nationals
- 13.3 pp more likely to hold a **formal job**

Unemployment and economic hardship show weaker links that are only marginally significant.

The takeaway is straightforward: legal status is not strongly associated with whether migrants *have* a job, but it is strongly associated with the *quality* of that job. The 30-point gap in bank account wages is particularly striking—it suggests that financial inclusion looks fundamentally different for legal and undocumented migrants, even after controlling for observable characteristics.

These patterns hold up. Using alternative definitions of the outcome variables produces virtually identical results (Appendix F).

## 4 Legal Status and Settlement Intentions

Given the strong link between legal status and job quality, one might expect legal migrants to be more likely to want to stay. They are not.

The estimated gap between legal and undocumented migrants in wanting to stay is just 1.3 percentage points—effectively zero. Both groups report wanting to stay at around 23%. Having papers, by itself, does not appear to make migrants more likely to settle.

This is a puzzle. If legal status opens the door to better jobs, why doesn't it also promote settlement?

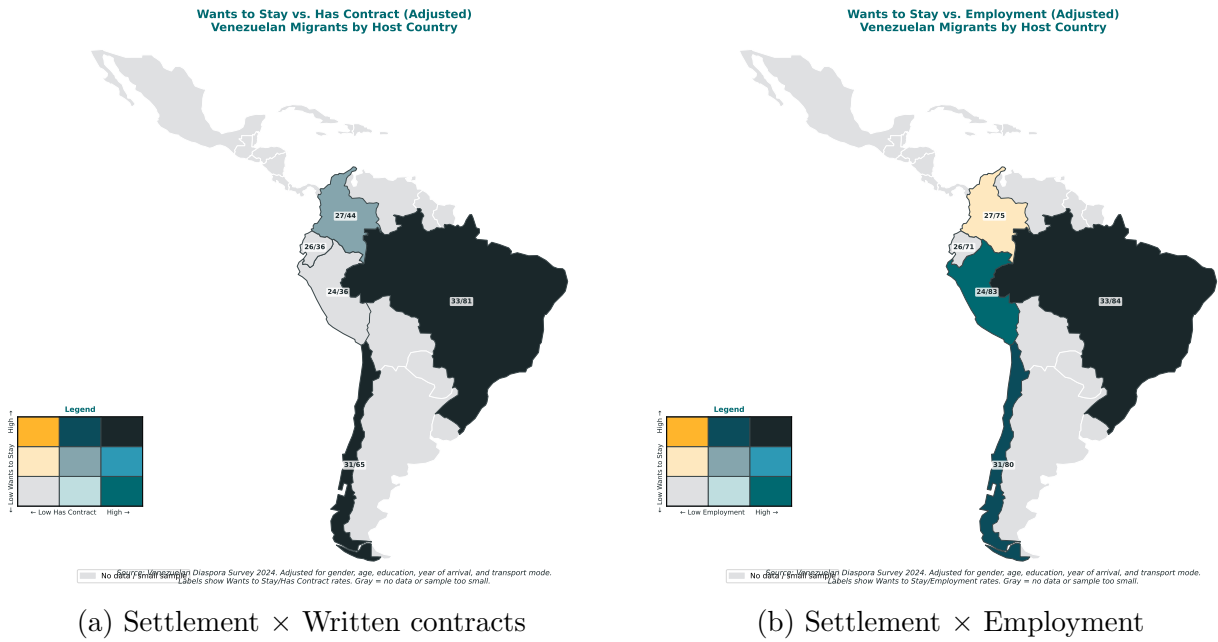
A descriptive look at the data offers a clue. Figure 3 maps the joint distribution of labor market outcomes and settlement intentions across host countries. Countries where both contract rates and settlement intentions are high—such as Argentina and Chile—suggest environments where labor market integration and settlement may go together. Brazil, despite having the highest contract rates, shows only moderate settlement intentions, hinting that other factors (economic conditions, proximity to home) also play a role. These geographic patterns motivate us to look more carefully at how labor market outcomes interact with legal status at the individual level.

### 4.1 The role of labor market integration

To dig deeper, we ask whether the link between legal status and settlement varies depending on labor market outcomes. Does legal status matter *more* for migrants who have good jobs than for those who do not? We test this by interacting legal status with each of our labor market indicators.

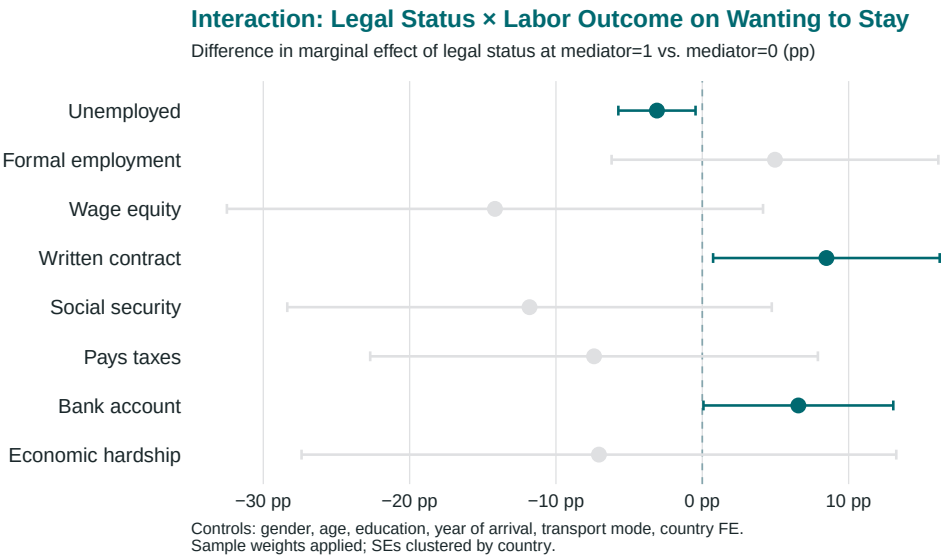
Figure 4 shows the results. Most interactions are noisy and not statistically significant. But three stand out.

Figure 3: Cross-country relationship between labor market outcomes and settlement intentions



*Notes:* These bivariate maps show the joint distribution of two variables at the country level among Venezuelan migrants. Source: Venezuelan Diaspora Survey 2024.

Figure 4: How labor market outcomes modify the link between legal status and wanting to stay



*Notes:* Each point shows how much the link between legal status and wanting to stay changes depending on the labor market indicator. Filled dots indicate statistically significant differences; hollow dots are not significant. Bars show 95% confidence intervals.



**Written contracts.** Among migrants *without* a contract, legal status has essentially no link to settlement intentions. But among those *with* a contract, legal status is associated with an 8.5 percentage-point higher desire to stay—a significant difference.

**Bank accounts.** The pattern is similar: among migrants who do *not* receive wages through a bank account, legal status has no detectable link to wanting to stay. Among those who *do*, the link rises by 6.6 pp.

**Unemployment.** The interaction runs in the expected direction: legal migrants who are unemployed are 3.1 pp *less* likely to want to stay than legal migrants with jobs.

Formal employment indicators are themselves *negatively* correlated with settlement among undocumented migrants. Having a contract or a bank account without legal status is associated with *lower* desire to stay. One interpretation is that undocumented migrants with formal jobs may feel especially vulnerable, as formal employment without legal backing creates tensions and risks that could discourage long-term plans.

These results hold under alternative variable definitions (Appendix F). Two caveats apply specifically to the interaction results. First, we cannot rule out reverse causality: migrants who intend to stay may be more likely to invest in formal employment, meaning the interaction could partly reflect settlement intentions driving formalization rather than the reverse. Second, because labor market outcomes are themselves associated with legal status, the interaction coefficients should be interpreted as descriptive conditional associations, not as evidence of a clean moderation channel.

The story that emerges from these patterns is suggestive. Legal status is associated with formal employment, but the mere possession of documents does not appear to predict settlement. Settlement intentions appear higher when legal status coincides with tangible labor market outcomes: a contract that provides security, a bank account that signals financial integration, and the stability that comes with formal work. Unemployed legal migrants have documents but lack economic foundations; they remain open to moving on. Employed legal migrants with contracts have both the legal right to stay and the economic reason to do so.

## 5 Policy Implications

What do these patterns mean for policy? While our results are correlational, they point to concrete implications for migration policy in Latin America and beyond.

**Regularization is necessary but may not be sufficient.** Prior causal evidence from large-scale amnesty programs shows that granting legal status improves labor market outcomes (Bahar et al., 2021; Kossoudji and Cobb-Clark, 2002), and our data corroborate this across every indicator we examine. Yet legal status alone is not correlated with migrants’ intentions to settle permanently. The link materializes only when legal status is paired with formal employment.

**Contracts and financial inclusion appear to be the missing links.** Among the labor market indicators we study, written employment contracts and bank account wages show the strongest interaction with legal status in predicting settlement intentions. This suggests that the most promising complements to regularization may be policies that directly target these two channels:



- *Support for formal contracting*, including information campaigns about labor rights and employer obligations toward migrant workers
- *Financial inclusion programs* that facilitate access to bank accounts and formal payment systems for newly regularized migrants
- *Recognition of foreign credentials* to help migrants access formal jobs that match their qualifications
- *Job placement services* that connect newly regularized migrants with formal employers

**Integration benefits host countries too.** Migrants who settle with formal employment contribute to the tax base, social security systems, and local economies. Countries that invest in integration infrastructure may see returns not only in migrant well-being but also in fiscal sustainability and social cohesion.

**The stakes extend beyond the region.** With millions of Venezuelans now living across Latin America, the question of whether migrants settle or move on has direct implications for the United States. Migrants who fail to integrate—who remain in informal jobs without contracts, without financial inclusion, and without a sense of stability—are more likely to continue northward, adding to irregular crossings at the US border. Our results suggest that effective integration in the first host country, combining legal status with access to formal employment, is associated with stronger settlement intentions. Prior causal evidence confirms that regularization improves labor market outcomes (Bahar et al., 2021; Kossoudji and Cobb-Clark, 2002). Whether formal employment in turn anchors migrants to the host country—as our interaction results suggest—remains an open question, but the pattern is consistent with a policy framework in which regularization and labor market integration work as complements. If so, investing in migrant integration in Latin America is not just good development policy, it is consistent with the goal of orderly migration that the US government has long pursued. This creates a rare alignment of interests: migrants gain stability and opportunity, host countries gain productive, tax-paying workers, and the United States sees reduced pressure from secondary migration. Working alongside partners in the region to expand regularization programs and strengthen labor market integration is a win for all parties involved.

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## Appendix A Data Collection Process

Data were collected by a private polling company between September 11 and September 17, 2024, using stratified river sampling through online advertisements—an opt-in, non-probability method that, with proper methodological considerations, has proven reliable for estimating public opinion ([Zhang et al., 2018](#)) and cost-effective for reaching hidden or hard-to-find populations ([Hoffmann Pham et al., 2019](#)) such as migrants.

The data collection followed four steps: First, the pollster created target demographic quotas based on official estimates from the Inter-agency Coordination Platform for Refugees and Migrants (R4V), which compiles migration data reported by host governments. Second, for each demographic group, the pollster used online advertisements to promote digital content inviting individuals to complete a self-administered questionnaire (ads were targeted by geographic location, age, gender, and digital footprints indicating the user had lived in Venezuela). Third, users accessed the survey through a digital questionnaire and self-reported their responses (eligibility was confirmed through the questionnaire by verifying demographics, Venezuelan origin, and multiple attention checks). Finally, the results were weighted using raking to correct any discrepancies between the sample and the target quotas.

## Appendix B Descriptive Statistics

Table B1 presents weighted means for key variables, disaggregated by legal status.

Table B1: Descriptive Statistics by Legal Status

| Variable                       | Sample   | All  |       | Legal |       | Undocumented |     | Diff (pp) |
|--------------------------------|----------|------|-------|-------|-------|--------------|-----|-----------|
|                                |          | %    | N     | %     | N     | %            | N   |           |
| Employed                       | Full     | 80.7 | 2,987 | 82.3  | 2,369 | 73.8         | 618 | 8.5       |
| Formal employment              | Employed | 62.0 | 2,351 | 64.3  | 1,919 | 51.2         | 432 | 13.1      |
| Perceives wage equity          | Employed | 61.1 | 1,900 | 64.6  | 1,554 | 43.8         | 346 | 20.8      |
| Has written contract           | Employed | 39.3 | 2,293 | 44.1  | 1,881 | 15.8         | 412 | 28.3      |
| Contributes to social security | Employed | 51.5 | 2,008 | 55.5  | 1,685 | 28.2         | 323 | 27.3      |
| Pays taxes                     | Employed | 50.2 | 2,001 | 53.7  | 1,669 | 31.7         | 332 | 22.0      |
| Paid via bank account          | Employed | 54.1 | 2,318 | 61.2  | 1,897 | 20.6         | 421 | 40.6      |
| Economic hardship              | Employed | 5.8  | 2,351 | 5.4   | 1,919 | 8.0          | 432 | -2.6      |
| Wants to stay                  | Full     | 23.2 | 2,987 | 23.2  | 2,369 | 23.2         | 618 | 0.0       |
| Has legal status               | Full     | 81.0 | 2,987 | —     | —     | —            | —   | —         |

*Notes:* Weighted means (in percentages) using survey sample weights. “Full” sample includes all respondents; “Employed” sample conditions on having any job. Diff = Legal – Undocumented, in percentage points. USA and Europe excluded from sample.

## Appendix C Sample Composition

Table C1: Sample Composition by Host Country

| Country            | Total        | Legal        | Undoc.     | % Legal     | % Employed  | % Want to Stay |
|--------------------|--------------|--------------|------------|-------------|-------------|----------------|
| Argentina          | 136          | 129          | 7          | 97.4        | 80.2        | 49.6           |
| Brazil             | 461          | 439          | 22         | 95.6        | 85.6        | 29.4           |
| Chile              | 485          | 276          | 209        | 56.3        | 82.0        | 28.3           |
| Colombia           | 585          | 475          | 110        | 79.9        | 77.7        | 22.6           |
| Ecuador            | 578          | 379          | 199        | 61.9        | 72.8        | 22.1           |
| Mexico             | 32           | 29           | 3          | 81.7        | 50.7        | 15.0           |
| Panama             | 60           | 56           | 4          | 83.4        | 86.9        | 36.2           |
| Peru               | 475          | 439          | 36         | 91.1        | 86.4        | 19.2           |
| Dominican Republic | 175          | 147          | 28         | 79.2        | 85.7        | 27.3           |
| <b>Total</b>       | <b>2,987</b> | <b>2,369</b> | <b>618</b> | <b>79.3</b> | <b>81.0</b> | <b>23.2</b>    |

*Notes:* Counts are unweighted; percentages are weighted using survey sample weights.  
USA and Europe excluded.

## Appendix D Sample Definition and Variable Construction

### Sample restrictions

The original survey collected 3,606 responses from Venezuelan migrants across eleven countries. We apply two sample restrictions. First, we exclude respondents in the United States ( $n = 358$ ) and Europe ( $n = 1$ ), where migration policy contexts differ fundamentally from those in Latin America. Second, we exclude respondents with missing legal status information ( $n = 260$ ), since legal status is the central variable in our analysis. The resulting analysis sample consists of 2,987 respondents across nine Latin American countries.

### Main explanatory variable

Legal status is coded as a binary indicator equal to one if the respondent reports possessing a visa, nationality, or equivalent documentation, and zero if they report having no legal migratory status. Respondents who preferred not to answer are excluded (see above).

### Outcome variables

All outcome variables are binary indicators constructed from categorical survey responses. Table D1 summarizes the construction of each variable.

Two construction choices merit explanation:

*Excluding “don’t know” responses.* Several survey questions (contract, social security, taxes, bank account, and wage equity) included a “No sabría decir” (“I wouldn’t know”) option. We exclude these respondents from the relevant outcome rather than coding them as zero, because a “don’t know” response is ambiguous: it could reflect genuine uncertainty

Table D1: Variable Definitions

| Variable                       | Equals 1 if            | Sample restriction      | N     |
|--------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------|-------|
| Unemployed                     | “No tengo trabajo”     | All respondents         | 2,987 |
| Formal employment              | “Tengo trabajo formal” | Employed only           | 2,351 |
| Perceives wage equity          | “No, gano lo mismo...” | Excl. “No sabría decir” | 1,900 |
| Has written contract           | “Sí”                   | Excl. “No sabría decir” | 2,293 |
| Contributes to social security | “Sí”                   | Excl. “No sabría decir” | 2,008 |
| Pays taxes                     | “Sí”                   | Excl. “No sabría decir” | 2,001 |
| Paid via bank account          | “Sí”                   | Excl. “No sabría decir” | 2,318 |
| Economic hardship              | “No puedo cubrir...”   | Employed only           | 2,351 |
| Wants to stay                  | “No” (to remigration)  | All respondents         | 2,987 |

*Notes:* “Employed only” excludes respondents who report being unemployed. “Excl. ‘No sabría decir’” excludes respondents who answered “I wouldn’t know” to the relevant question, as this response is ambiguous between genuine uncertainty and a true negative. The formal employment variable is defined among employed respondents only because unemployment is modeled as a separate outcome. N refers to the number of non-missing observations available for each variable.

or an unwillingness to report. In Appendix F, we show that recoding “don’t know” as zero produces virtually identical results.

*Formal employment among employed respondents.* We define formal employment as holding a formal job conditional on being employed, rather than among all respondents. This avoids conflating the extensive margin (having any job) with the intensive margin (having a formal job). Unemployment is modeled as a separate outcome with the full sample.

## Interaction models

In the interaction analysis (Section 4), we interact legal status with each labor market indicator as a binary mediator. The mediator takes the value one if the respondent reports the positive outcome (e.g., has a contract) and zero otherwise, using the same “clean” definitions described above. The interaction coefficient captures whether the link between legal status and settlement intentions differs between migrants with and without that labor market outcome.

## Appendix E Regression Results

For each outcome  $Y_i$  we estimate the following linear probability model:

$$Y_i = \alpha + \beta \cdot \text{Legal}_i + X_i' \gamma + \delta_c + \varepsilon_i \quad (1)$$

where  $\text{Legal}_i$  is a binary indicator for having legal documentation,  $X_i$  is a vector of individual controls (gender, age, education, year of arrival, mode of transport),  $\delta_c$  are country fixed effects, and  $\varepsilon_i$  is the error term. For the interaction analysis (Table E2), we augment the model with a labor market mediator  $M_i$  and an interaction term  $\text{Legal}_i \times M_i$ . Standard errors are clustered by host country, and survey sample weights are applied throughout.

Because our sample spans only nine country clusters—fewer than the approximately 50 recommended for reliable asymptotic inference (Cameron et al., 2008)—cluster-robust standard errors may understate true uncertainty, and  $p$ -values should be interpreted with caution. We note, however, that our main results are robust to restricting the sample to the five largest country groups (Appendix G), and that point estimates remain stable even as confidence intervals widen.

Table E1 reports the association between legal status and each outcome. Table E2 reports the interaction models for settlement intentions.

Table E1: Association between Legal Status and Labor Market Outcomes

| Outcome                                                                                                                                                                                | Coef. (pp) | SE     | <i>p</i> -value | N     |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|--------|-----------------|-------|
| Unemployed                                                                                                                                                                             | -4.64*     | (2.23) | 0.072           | 2,987 |
| Formal employment                                                                                                                                                                      | 13.32***   | (3.37) | 0.004           | 2,351 |
| Perceives wage equity                                                                                                                                                                  | 15.46***   | (3.59) | 0.003           | 1,900 |
| Has written contract                                                                                                                                                                   | 21.64***   | (4.04) | 0.001           | 2,293 |
| Contributes to social security                                                                                                                                                         | 21.62***   | (3.53) | 0.000           | 2,008 |
| Pays taxes                                                                                                                                                                             | 16.47***   | (2.75) | 0.000           | 2,001 |
| Paid via bank account                                                                                                                                                                  | 30.51***   | (5.99) | 0.001           | 2,318 |
| Economic hardship                                                                                                                                                                      | -3.32*     | (1.72) | 0.089           | 2,351 |
| Wants to stay                                                                                                                                                                          | 1.33       | (4.81) | 0.790           | 2,987 |
| Controls                                                                                                                                                                               | Yes        |        |                 |       |
| Country FE                                                                                                                                                                             | Yes        |        |                 |       |
| <i>R-squared by row:</i> Unemployed 0.058; Formal 0.067; Wage equity 0.089; Contract 0.180; Soc. sec. 0.153; Taxes 0.173; Bank acct. 0.219; Econ. hardship 0.044; Wants to stay 0.025. |            |        |                 |       |

*Notes:* OLS estimates from separate regressions of each outcome on a legal status indicator. Coefficients in percentage points. N varies because some outcomes condition on employment and/or exclude “don’t know” responses (see Appendix D). Controls: gender, age, education, year of arrival, transport mode, country fixed effects. Sample weights applied. Standard errors clustered by country in parentheses. \*  $p < 0.10$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .



Table E2: Association between Legal Status and Wanting to Stay in Host Country

|                         | (1)<br>No inter. | (2)<br>Unemp.     | (3)<br>Formal   | (4)<br>Wage eq.   | (5)<br>Contract    | (6)<br>Soc. sec. | (7)<br>Taxes    | (8)<br>Bank acct.  | (9)<br>Hardship |
|-------------------------|------------------|-------------------|-----------------|-------------------|--------------------|------------------|-----------------|--------------------|-----------------|
| Legal status            | 1.33<br>(4.81)   | 2.10<br>(4.72)    | -0.65<br>(6.92) | 7.66<br>(6.26)    | 0.32<br>(6.07)     | 4.88<br>(3.47)   | 4.42<br>(3.64)  | 1.38<br>(5.67)     | 3.08<br>(4.75)  |
| Mediator                |                  | 2.22<br>(3.15)    | 2.13<br>(3.70)  | 15.14**<br>(6.21) | -6.49***<br>(1.47) | 9.56<br>(6.75)   | 6.93<br>(7.16)  | -8.87***<br>(2.64) | -3.21<br>(4.29) |
| Legal status × Mediator |                  | -3.10**<br>(1.14) | 4.97<br>(4.84)  | -14.17<br>(7.94)  | 8.48**<br>(3.36)   | -11.81<br>(7.18) | -7.40<br>(6.63) | 6.57**<br>(2.81)   | -7.06<br>(8.81) |
| Controls                | Yes              | Yes               | Yes             | Yes               | Yes                | Yes              | Yes             | Yes                | Yes             |
| Observations            | 2,987            | 2,987             | 2,351           | 1,900             | 2,293              | 2,008            | 2,001           | 2,318              | 2,351           |
| $R^2$                   | 0.025            | 0.026             | 0.031           | 0.036             | 0.026              | 0.033            | 0.040           | 0.027              | 0.028           |

*Notes:* OLS estimates. Dependent variable: wants to stay in host country (binary). All coefficients in percentage points. Column (1) shows the unconditional effect of legal status. Columns (2)–(9) show OLS coefficients from models interacting legal status with each labor market mediator. Controls: gender, age, education, year of arrival, mode of transport, country fixed effects. Sample weights applied. Standard errors clustered by country in parentheses. USA and Europe excluded. Ambiguous survey responses (“don’t know”) excluded from mediator definitions. \*  $p < 0.10$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .

## Appendix F Robustness: Alternative Variable Definitions

Several survey questions included a “don’t know” response option. Our main analysis excludes these respondents from the relevant outcome. As a robustness check, we re-estimate all models using a “broad” definition that recodes “don’t know” as zero. Tables F1 and F2 show that results are virtually unchanged.

Table F1: Robustness: Alternative Variable Definitions — Labor Outcomes

| Outcome                        | Baseline (excl. “don’t know”) |        |       | Broad (“don’t know” → 0) |        |       |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------|--------|-------|--------------------------|--------|-------|
|                                | Coef. (pp)                    | SE     | N     | Coef. (pp)               | SE     | N     |
| Perceives wage equity          | 15.46***                      | (3.59) | 1,900 | 14.26***                 | (3.84) | 2,351 |
| Has written contract           | 21.64***                      | (4.04) | 2,293 | 21.68***                 | (4.10) | 2,351 |
| Contributes to social security | 21.62***                      | (3.53) | 2,008 | 20.45***                 | (3.16) | 2,351 |
| Pays taxes                     | 16.47***                      | (2.75) | 2,001 | 15.34***                 | (3.04) | 2,351 |
| Paid via bank account          | 30.51***                      | (5.99) | 2,318 | 30.25***                 | (5.87) | 2,351 |

*Notes:* OLS estimates. “Baseline” excludes respondents who answered “don’t know” from the outcome definition. “Broad” recodes “don’t know” as 0 (i.e., absence of the characteristic). All other specifications identical: controls for gender, age, education, year of arrival, transport mode, country FE. Sample weights applied; SEs clustered by country. \*  $p < 0.10$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .

Table F2: Robustness: Alternative Variable Definitions — Interaction Associations with Wanting to Stay

| Mediator         | Baseline (excl. “don’t know”) |        |       | Broad (“don’t know” → 0) |        |       |
|------------------|-------------------------------|--------|-------|--------------------------|--------|-------|
|                  | $\beta_{int}$ (pp)            | SE     | N     | $\beta_{int}$ (pp)       | SE     | N     |
| Wage equity      | -14.17                        | (7.94) | 1,900 | -8.86                    | (6.64) | 2,351 |
| Written contract | 8.48**                        | (3.36) | 2,293 | 8.27**                   | (3.34) | 2,351 |
| Social security  | -11.81                        | (7.18) | 2,008 | -10.89**                 | (4.22) | 2,351 |
| Pays taxes       | -7.40                         | (6.63) | 2,001 | -7.14                    | (5.61) | 2,351 |
| Bank account     | 6.57**                        | (2.81) | 2,318 | 5.93*                    | (3.18) | 2,351 |

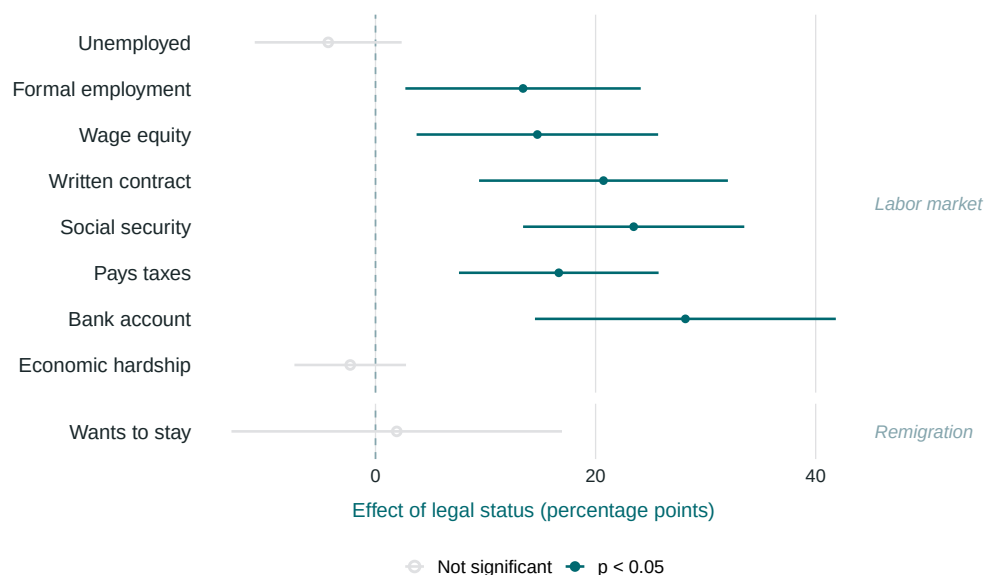
*Notes:* OLS estimates. Reported coefficient is the interaction term (Legal status  $\times$  Mediator) from models predicting “wants to stay.” “Baseline” excludes “don’t know” respondents from mediator definition; “Broad” recodes them as 0. Controls: gender, age, education, year of arrival, transport mode, country FE. Sample weights applied; SEs clustered by country. \*  $p < 0.10$ , \*\*  $p < 0.05$ , \*\*\*  $p < 0.01$ .

## Appendix G Robustness: Restricted Country Sample

As discussed in Section 2, four of the nine surveyed countries—Argentina, Mexico, Panama, and the Dominican Republic—have sample sizes too small for reliable country-level inference. To verify that our main results are not driven by the inclusion of these countries, we re-estimate all models using only the five countries with individually representative samples: Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Ecuador, and Peru. This reduces the sample from 2,987 to 2,584 respondents and the number of country clusters from nine to five.

Figures G1 and G2 replicate the main coefficient plots using this restricted sample. Panel A results are virtually identical: all six core labor market outcomes remain statistically significant with nearly unchanged point estimates. Panel B interaction results show stable point estimates but wider confidence intervals, reflecting the loss of statistical power from fewer clusters. The contract and bank account interactions, which are significant at the 5% level in the full sample, become marginally significant in the restricted sample—consistent with a power reduction rather than a change in the underlying pattern.

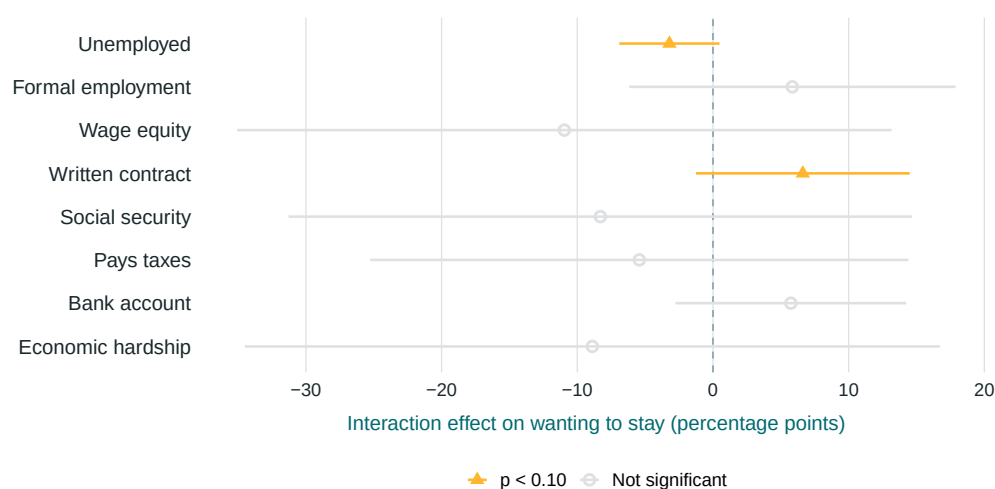
Figure G1: Legal status and labor market outcomes (5-country sample)



Notes: Sample restricted to Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Ecuador, and Peru ( $N = 2,584$ ).  
OLS with country fixed effects, demographic controls, and sample weights. SEs clustered by country.

Notes: Sample restricted to Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Ecuador, and Peru ( $N = 2,584$ ). See Figure 2 notes for specification details.

Figure G2: Interaction effects on wanting to stay (5-country sample)



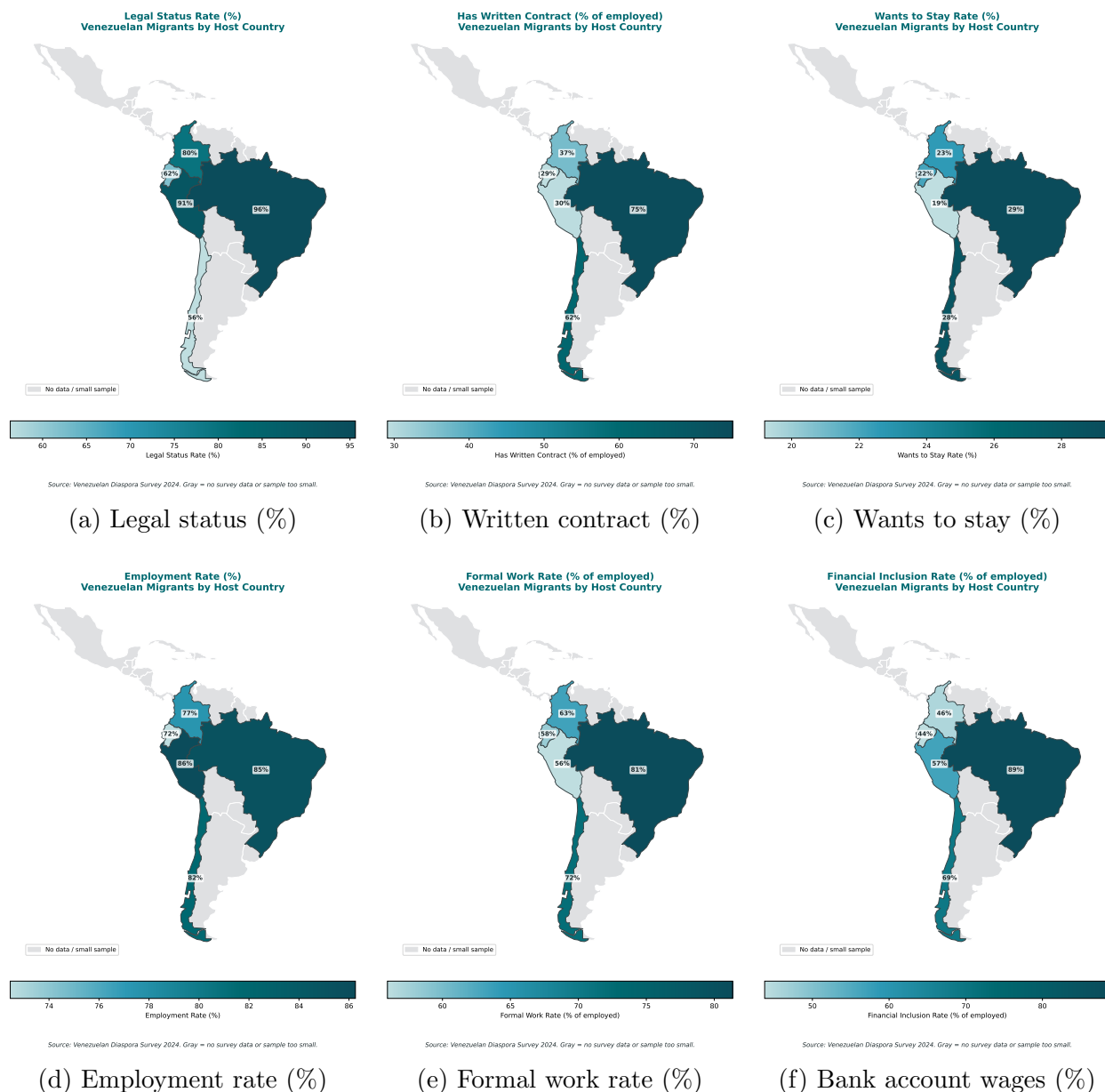
Notes: Sample restricted to Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Ecuador, and Peru.  
Interaction coefficients from OLS models. Controls: country FE, demographics.  
Sample weights. SEs clustered by country. Wider CIs reflect fewer clusters (5 vs. 9).

Notes: Sample restricted to Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Ecuador, and Peru. See Figure 4 notes for specification details. Point estimates are stable; wider confidence intervals reflect fewer clusters (5 vs. 9).

## Appendix H Unadjusted Maps

The maps below show raw (unadjusted) weighted means for each variable by host country. These complement the adjusted maps in Figure 1, which control for differences in demographics and migration history across countries.

Figure H1: Key variables by host country (unadjusted)



*Notes:* All figures are raw weighted percentages, not adjusted for demographics or migration history. Argentina, Mexico, Panama, and the Dominican Republic are shown in gray (sample too small for country-level inference). Source: Venezuelan Diaspora Survey 2024.